

Knight in shining IAA-armor

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Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By MARTINA SAPIO with JORDYN DAHL SNEAK PEEK — A consensus is building in the E

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure.

By MARTINA SAPIO

with JORDYN DAHL

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SNEAK PEEK

— A consensus is building in the European Parliament that the Industrial Accelerator Act is one of the EU's best weapons to counter China.

— European lawmakers broadly welcomed the Commission's push to make booking cross-border trains easier.

— Turkish carrier Pegasus canceled most of its Moscow flights overnight after Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy warned airlines and insurers that Russian airspace is becoming "unsafe."

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

WARMING UP TO IAA: The growing threat of China killing off what's left of Europe's industry is making the Industrial Accelerator Act more palatable to both lawmakers and industries. Auto supplier lobby CLEPA and German automaker Volkswagen lobbied for strict local content requirements to be put into place during a public hearing on the IAA at the European Parliament Wednesday.

Make up extra costs: VW put its weight behind the IAA when the file was first put forward in February. But sourcing more components in the EU won't be cheap, its chief Brussels lobbyist Sebastian Schaffer told lawmakers. "It would often be cheaper to source everything from China, to be very clear and blunt about this. That is why it is so crucial that incentives make up for the additional costs of our products."

The IAA is designed partly to limit Chinese investments in strategic sectors like EVs and raw materials. It would also set "Made in Europe" requirements for public procurement, potentially excluding Chinese suppliers.

Toward a small "Made in Europe" club: Consensus is building around a tight list of countries whose products would qualify as "Made in Europe" for certain public procurement sectors and subsidies. The three committees in charge of the IAA in Parliament — industry, internal market and international

trade— are on track to issue a draft report on the bill next week. It will include recommendations for “Made in Europe” to apply to the EU27, with an opt-in mechanism for close trading partners, one of the lawmakers told our colleague Francesca Micheletti.

No silver bullet: Multiple lawmakers and the panelists at the Parliament hearing reiterated that the IAA will help the EU’s industries, but it is not a saving grace. “This is not the silver bullet. Yes, we need to get it right. But we also need to make sure that Europe is and stays a destination for investments,” said Benjamin Krieger, secretary-general of CLEPA.

Sleeping walking: EU policymakers and the bloc’s industries are to blame for the current precarious position, said Green MEP Anna Cavazzini, who is co-leading the file. “All of us need to reflect also on how we here ... to the fact that we sleepwalked into this situation with the second China [export] shock [the first came after China joined the World Trade Organization in 2001].”

Read more from Jordyn and Francesca [here](#) .

The Moroccan car problem: Lawmakers’ attention is now turning to how to prevent China from circumventing the rules by relocating final stages of production to a friendly trading partner. The typical example is China’s strategy of establishing backdoor manufacturing hubs in Morocco .

What’s next: The lead MEPs are due to publish their report next week (Sept. 8), before a joint committee session on Sept. 28, after which other MEPs can file amendments. The committee vote is scheduled for Dec. 1, before a possible plenary vote in mid-December.

RAIL

ONE TICKET TO RIDE: European lawmakers broadly welcomed the Commission’s push to make booking cross-border trains as easy as booking a flight at the first TRAN Committee meeting after the summer break Wednesday — although the fight over exactly how much rail operators and booking platforms should be forced to cooperate is only beginning.

The pitch: The Commission’s passenger package would make it easier to find and combine journeys involving different rail companies, strengthen protections when passengers miss connections and regulate multimodal booking platforms. DG MOVE Director General Magda Kopczyńska told lawmakers voluntary cooperation between operators hasn’t delivered results: “If the agreements worked, if they covered all operators, we wouldn’t need to legislate.”

Broadly aboard: There was unusual agreement across political groups on the basic destination: Passengers shouldn’t need to understand which company operates each leg of their journey or to buy tickets across multiple websites. Kai Tegethoff, Parliament’s rapporteur on rail ticketing, said passengers should be able to “find the journeys, book on whatever platform they choose” and know they are protected for the entire trip.

A mobile roaming moment? S&D’s Lara Wolters wants lawmakers to be ambitious, comparing the opportunity to the EU’s abolition of mobile roaming charges. Rail’s fragmented ticketing system “cannot compete with the ease and choice of booking flights,” she said, arguing that easier booking should ultimately bring more passengers, revenue and investment into the sector. Her colleague Andreas Schieder stressed the other half of the equation: Passengers shouldn’t lose protection simply because a journey involves several railway companies.

Moving quickly: The Irish Council presidency wants a general approach by the end of the year, while Parliament's three rapporteurs have agreed to coordinate their timelines across the package. TRAN will get a more technical briefing on Sept. 9.

Meanwhile, DNSH: Before turning to tickets, TRAN also approved its opinion on the EU performance regulation — a proposal that would create a single, common framework for measuring and reporting the performance of the EU's next long-term budget. The EPP backed the final compromise despite maintaining its opposition to the "do no significant harm" principle, while Greens welcomed the committee preserving the climate and biodiversity safeguards. "We are happy with the outcome, especially compared to what happened in some other opinion-giving committees," Tegethoff told Martina.

BUY EUROPEAN, SAY INFRASTRUCTURE INDUSTRIES: Europe's rail, construction and dredging industries are joining forces to demand a stronger European preference in the EU's upcoming Public Procurement Act, arguing that strategic infrastructure contracts should favor European suppliers and be better protected from subsidized third-country competitors.

Keep some suppliers out: In a statement shared with POLITICO in advance, the groups argued that key technologies and services should not be provided by companies from countries that lack reciprocal access to EU procurement markets. They want the Commission to be able to make such exclusions mandatory on security grounds, while allowing contracting authorities to consider "strategic, security, and resilience" factors when choosing bidders.

China in the background: The statement doesn't single out Beijing, but the push comes after repeated concerns about subsidized foreign companies competing for European infrastructure contracts. The groups want lessons from the EU's Foreign Subsidies Regulation incorporated into procurement rules, including greater scrutiny of companies previously found to have benefited from distortive foreign subsidies.

CARS

PLUG-IN HYBRIDS EMIT MORE CO₂: A new study out today from the International Council on Clean Transportation shows plug-in hybrids emit more CO₂ than official estimates. The real-world emissions from hybrids registered in 2021 were 3.5 times the official value, while hybrids registered in 2023 emitted 4.6 times more, the study found.

Utility factor drama: This so-called utility factor is based on lab results and estimates the emissions from plug-in hybrids based on how much consumers use the electric motor versus the combustion engine. The Commission wants to update the factor in 2027 to reflect real-world data that shows people drive on the combustion engine more frequently. The automotive sector is lobbying for the calculation to remain unchanged, arguing it will make it harder to reach the EU's emission targets for automakers.

Longer range: The ICCT says the study shows that hybrids having longer electrical range does not lead to fewer emissions from the vehicle. "Plug-in hybrids registered in 2023 emitted almost 5 times more CO₂ on the road than their official values suggest, and the discrepancy has grown over the years," Jan Dornoff, the author, said in a statement.

AVIATION

RUSSIAN AIRSPACE WARNING HITS FLIGHTS: Turkish low-cost carrier Pegasus cancelled most of its Moscow flights overnight after Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy warned airlines and insurers

that Russian airspace is becoming “completely unsafe” amid growing drone activity, our colleague Daria Zakharova reports.

Grounded: Pegasus cancelled flights between Moscow’s Vnukovo Airport and Istanbul, Bodrum and Antalya, while five of six incoming services from Turkey were pushed back to Sept. 3. The disruption began with a Bodrum-Moscow flight that was canceled while passengers were already boarding.

Kyiv’s warning: Zelenskyy stressed that Ukraine does not “threaten civilian aviation as such,” but said airlines need to account for the growing scale of drone operations over Russia. Kyiv has stepped up long-range attacks in recent months, including large barrages reaching deep into Russian territory.

Correlation, not confirmation: Pegasus itself did not link the cancellations to Zelenskyy’s remarks, blaming “technical and operational reasons” and saying flights from Sept. 2 onward would operate as scheduled. Turkish Airlines, meanwhile, continued operating most of its Moscow services, cancelling only two of roughly 25 departures.

URGENT ATC REFORMS NEEDED: Ryanair lambasted Greek aviation authorities on Wednesday after an equipment failure caused the cancellation of 37 Ryanair flights, affecting nearly 7,000 passengers. The Irish airline again called on the Commission to urgently reform the country’s air traffic control system.

State failure: The latest malfunction is the fourth in the past 12 months, the airline said, which “once again exposes the complete failure of the Greek government to properly manage and fund its ATC infrastructure.”

PIT STOPS

Ryanair cut the number of flights planned for this winter due to high fuel prices, warning that airfares could rise next year.

Headlines

Here’s a recap of yesterday’s news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

China threat bolsters support for EU industrial policy

Industry officials at the European Parliament backed the Commission’s Industrial Accelerator Act proposal.

By Jordyn Dahl, Francesca Micheletti · Sept 02, 2026, 07:14 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

EU lawmakers demand stronger industrial policy bill as China threat rises

A sense of urgency on Europe’s industry is growing, said German Green MEP Anna Cavazzini.

By Francesca Micheletti · Sept 02, 2026, 12:19 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

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